RURAL & LANDSCAPE PLANNING

Defining rurality

- 2nd lecture -

Lecturer:
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Defining rurality

- What do we mean by rural?

- Policy definitions of rural
  >> rural as a social construct
  >> contested and diverse ruralities
  >> the global countryside
  >> is 'rural' a useful concept for spatial policy and planning?

- Who is the countryside for and what is its role and function?

Lecture outline

Key questions:

- **What is meant by 'rural'?**
- Is there a specific rural dimension to planning / policymaking?

Approaches to understanding rurality

Key takeaways

What does 'rural' mean?

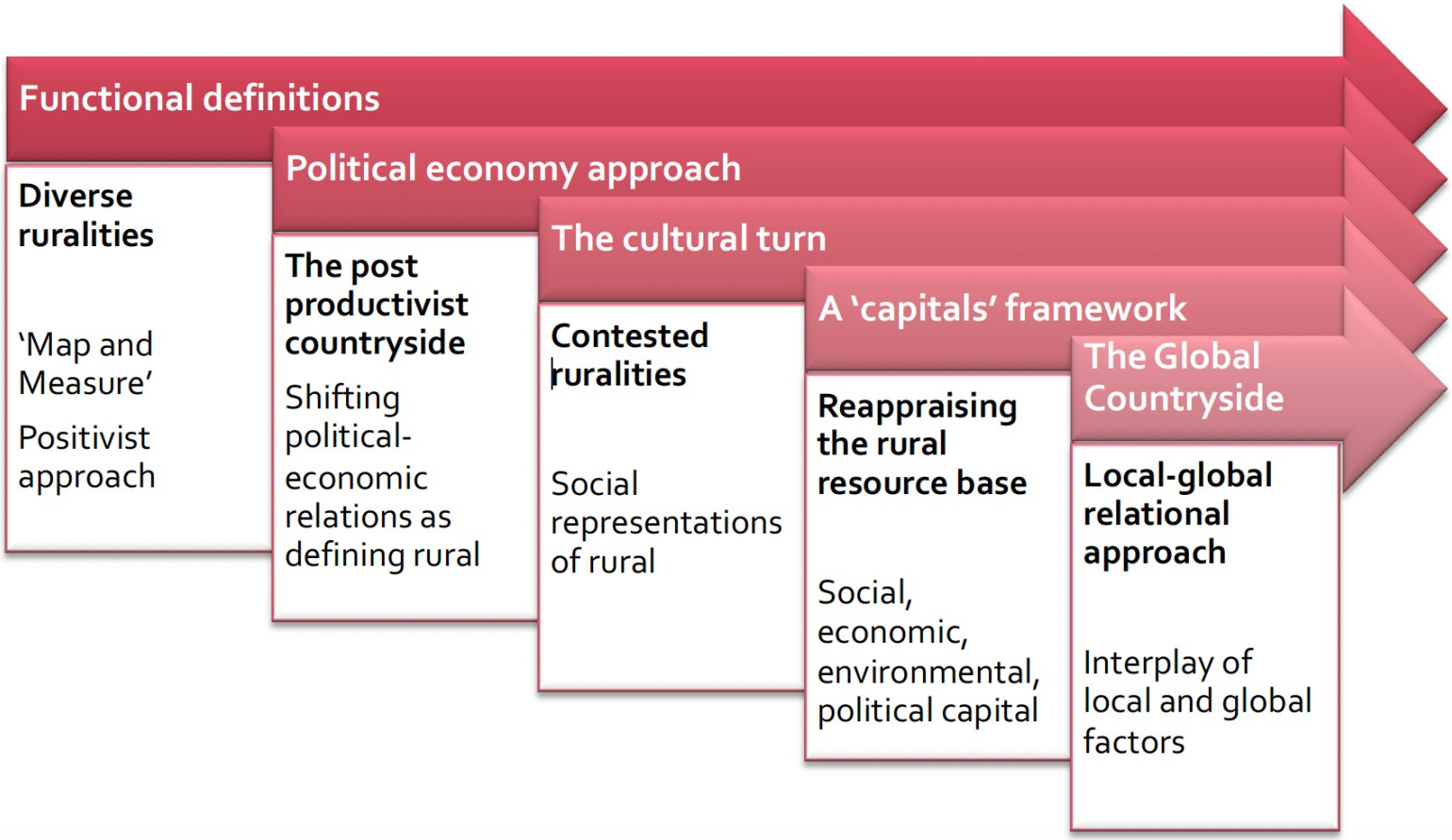
- Literature review: a definition of 'rural' proves **elusive** – but remains a common term in both academic, policy and everyday language

- Does the concept travel well?
  >> Rural / Country / Countryside / Outback / Wilderness / Regional / Provinces / Periphery

- How useful and helpful is the concept of 'rural' for **policy-makers**?

>> 'rural': beyond farming, housing, conservation, infrastructure and economic development

Alternative approaches to understanding rurality: summary

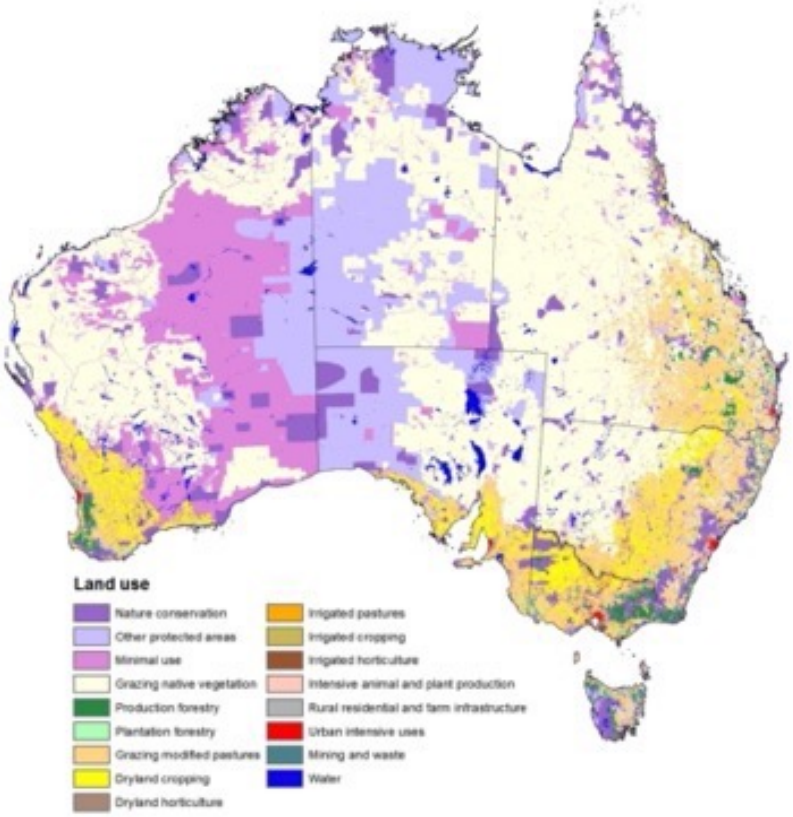


1 Functional approach to rurality

- Identify **functional elements** of rural place/society/environment, e.g.:
  land-use;
  economy; employment;
  geographic location;
  population; settlements;
  service provision;
  other quantifiable indicators

- Largely **empirical accounts** of the changing rural condition

- **'Map + Measure'**



1 Functional approach to rurality

Rural areas - definition:

- are dominated by **extensive land uses** e.g., agriculture, forestry
- contain **small, lower-order settlements** which demonstrate a strong relationship with the landscape
- cause a way of life which is characterised by a **cohesive identity** and behavioural qualities of living as part of an extensive landscape

1 Functional approach to rurality

Examples:

- Very common in rural policymaking: e.g., farm size, farm output
- Planning policy: peripherality, settlement size and type

Strengths:

- Descriptive; identification of trends

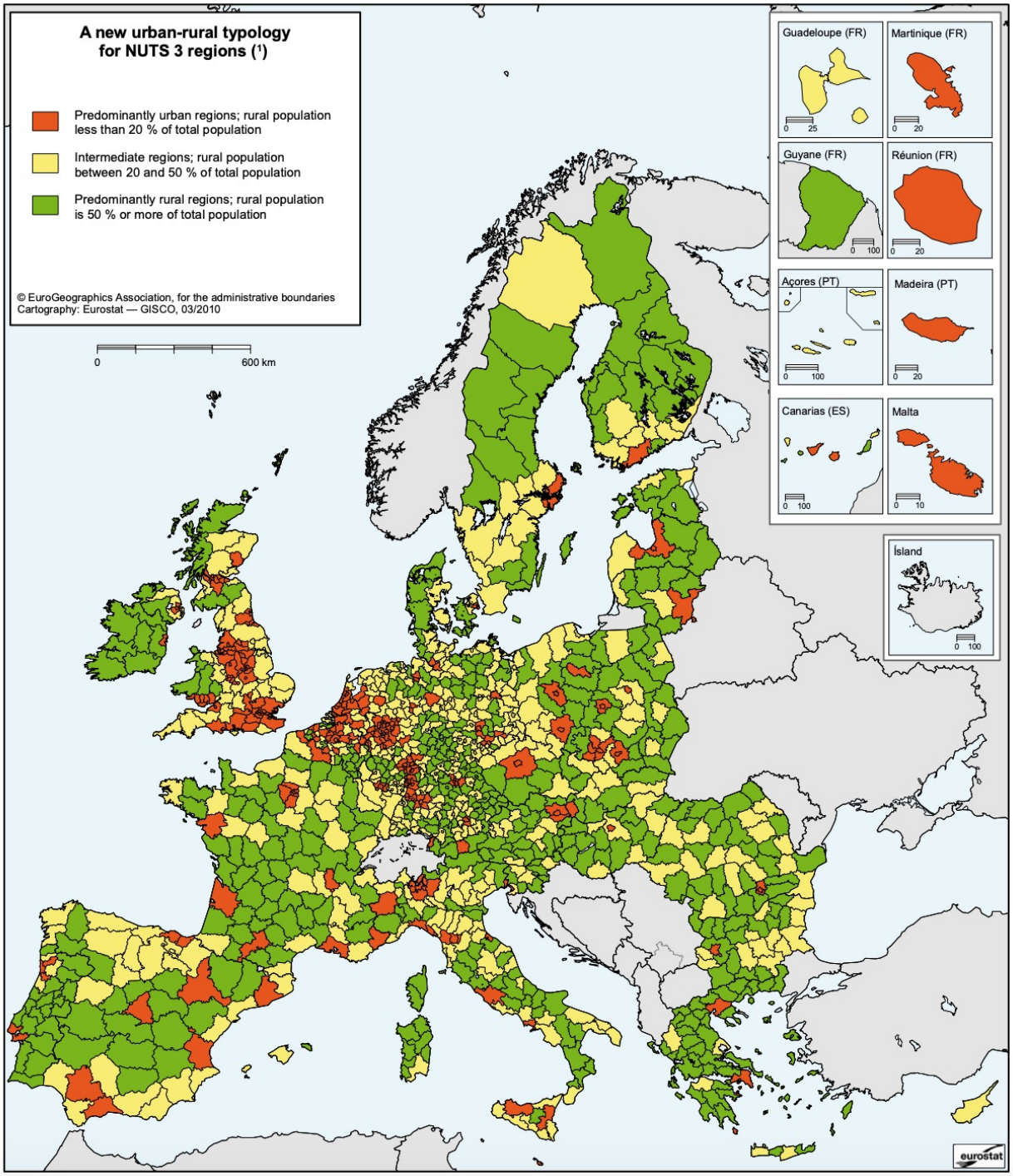
Weaknesses:

- Criticised as 'theory-free' and, therefore, value-free
  >> other approaches appeared as a reaction to the **objectivity of functional approach**

1 Functional approach to rurality

Example:
The OECD classification of rural

>> Land: 83% of land in OECD countries are in predominately rural areas



1 Functional approach to rurality - critique

- In understanding spatial/social change, **rural is not explanatory** or a causal mechanism
- Remote **rural and inner-city communities face similar challenges,** and the root causes are often found outside these places

Hoggart, K. (1990). Let's do away with rural. *Journal of Rural Studies, 6*(3), 245-257.

- We live in an age of **planetary urbanisation**
- Rural is a chaotic concept: the continued use of urban and rural as opposing analytical concepts and **dividing human settlement** space into urban and rural containers **is not justified**

Brenner, N. & Schmid, C. (2014). The 'urban age' in question. *International Journal of Urban and Regional Research, 38*(3), 731-755.

1 Functional approach to rurality - critique

- Revisiting of the theme of rural restructuring by examining the emerging urban-rural relationship and the **influence of urbanisation and globalisation on rural life**

- There is a greater interpenetration of rural and urban life and a **blurring of rural-urban spatial and social boundaries** – this pace of change is accelerating

>> rurban – urban-rural regions

Lichter, D. & Brown, D. (2011). Rural America in an Urban Society: Changing Spatial and Social Boundaries. *Annual Review of Sociology, 37*, 565-592.

1 Functional approach to rurality - aesthetics

In addition to functionality, planners have traditionally also defined rural in **aesthetic terms**:

- landscape; scenic quality; sublime/beauty
- early preoccupation of planners (related to architecture-planner culture)
- 'moral and aesthetic notion of the environment as backcloth and setting'
- **Examples:**
  National Parks; Areas of Outstanding Natural Beauty; Special Areas of Conservation; preservation of important views, skylines

1 Functional approach to rurality - aesthetics

1 Functional approach to rurality: aesthetics critique

Strengths:

- Landscape and cultural heritage
- Linked to tourism

Weaknesses:

- Views the environment as a collection of *natural* assets
- Narrow framework for enhancing the environment
- No community dimension

2 Political economy approaches

- Emphasizes the politics of place and **power struggles** to examine **rural change**
- Key departure point in analysis – **the 'demise' of agriculture**

>> Seminal UK studies in 1990s (Marsden, Munton, Murdoch)

2 Political economy approaches:
post-productivist countryside

Two key themes:

1. **Post-productivist:**
   >> the dominant concerns of **productivist agriculture are declining** in the face of competing **consumption** interests

2. **'Differentiated countryside':**
   >> new patterns of diversity and differentiation are emerging across rural space in relation to **governance and regulative processes**

2 Political economy approaches: 'differentiated countryside'

1. An anti-development '**preserved' countryside** with *middle classes* dominating decision-making

2. A '**contested' countryside** beyond commuter catchments – *landowners / farmers* play a leading political role

3. A '**paternalistic' countryside** dominated by *private estates* – landed status is the basis of power

4. A '**clientelist' countryside** where welfare of deeper *rural communities* is main concern – agricultural corporatism strong – all about development of 'peripheral' economies and areas

Lowe, P., Marsden, T., Murdoch, J. & Ward, N. (2005). *The differentiated countryside.* London: Routledge.

2 Political economy approaches:
new rural conflicts

- The **decline in agricultural employment**
  >> caused by transition of production to emerging economies
- **Environmentalism** as a powerful ethic and political force
  >> opposed to the (pro-)growth narrative
- Emergence of **new uses and demands** for rural space
  >> beyond production
- **Increased personal mobility** – commuting, migration, tourism
  >> no traditional rural identity
- **Social exclusion**
  >> new winners and losers from change processes

3 The cultural turn in rural studies

Rural as a **'social construction':**

- The **'cultural turn'** in rural studies
  (Pratt, 1996; Cloke, 1997; Phillips et al, 2001)
- Considers rurality as **socially and culturally constructed** – and therefore a contested concept
- Methodology: qualitative; ethnography; discourse or interpretive analysis

3 The cultural turn in rural studies

Rural as a **'social construction':**

Research focuses on:

- *Lay discourses* of the rural: *peoples'* everyday **interpretation of rurality** (e.g., Cloke, 1997; Jones, 1995)
- *Policy discourses* of the rural: the *policy community's* **interpretation of rurality** (e.g., Richardson, 2000; Scott, 2005)

>> Example: The 'Rural Idyll'

3 The cultural turn in rural studies: contested meanings of the countryside

>> Example: The 'Rural Idyll'
>> variety of meanings

Rural communities **VERSUS** **Conservation interests**

- Land
- Working countryside
- Function
- Community sustainability

- Landscape
- Preserved countryside
- Aesthetic
- Ecological integrity and environmental sustainability

3 The cultural turn in rural studies: the politics of the rural

- Understanding **conflicts** **as a new politics of the rural** with varying interpretations and framing of rurality surrounding nature, environment and landscape

- Dominated by the narratives of rurality/nature which often position rural areas (and landscapes) as pure, idyllic and vulnerable, placing **limits on acceptable development**

Woods, M. (2003). Conflicting environmental visions of the rural: windfarm development in Mid Wales. *Sociologia ruralis, 43*(3), 271-288.

>> 'cultural turn' (pro & contra) has lost sight of the 'politics of place' (manifold viewpoints)
>> evolution: **fusion of political economy and cultural turn**

3 The cultural turn in rural studies: implications for planning practice

Is the cultural turn in rural studies relevant to planning policy?

- Discourse analysis useful tool in revealing different **policy perspectives**
- **How the rural is interpreted** is central in formulating policy responses
- Lay discourses can help us **understand the rural condition** – e.g., why is the countryside a popular residential environment?

3 The cultural turn in rural studies: implications for planning practice

Lay discourses can help us **understand the rural condition:**

THE IRISH TIMES Environment

News Sport Business Debate Life & Style Cultu

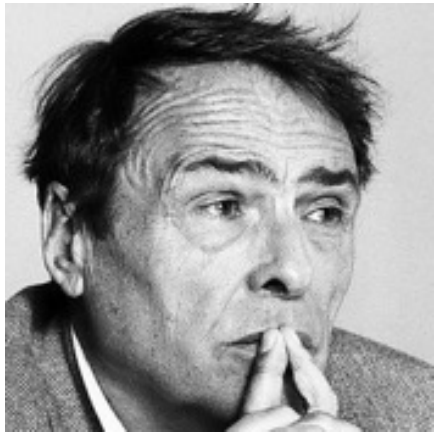
News / Environment

Suspicion of EirGrid pylon plans is deep and pervasive across country

Locals are angry at what they see as contempt for their concerns

Anti-pylon campaigner Paddy Massey in front of the local information centre in Lismore, Co Waterford. Photograph: David Sleator

4 A ‘capitals’ framework for rurality



Pierre Bourdieu’s ‘Forms of Capital’ (1986)

>> Economic / Cultural / Social Capital

- Re-appraising the **rural resource base**
- An **assets-based approach** for rural policy

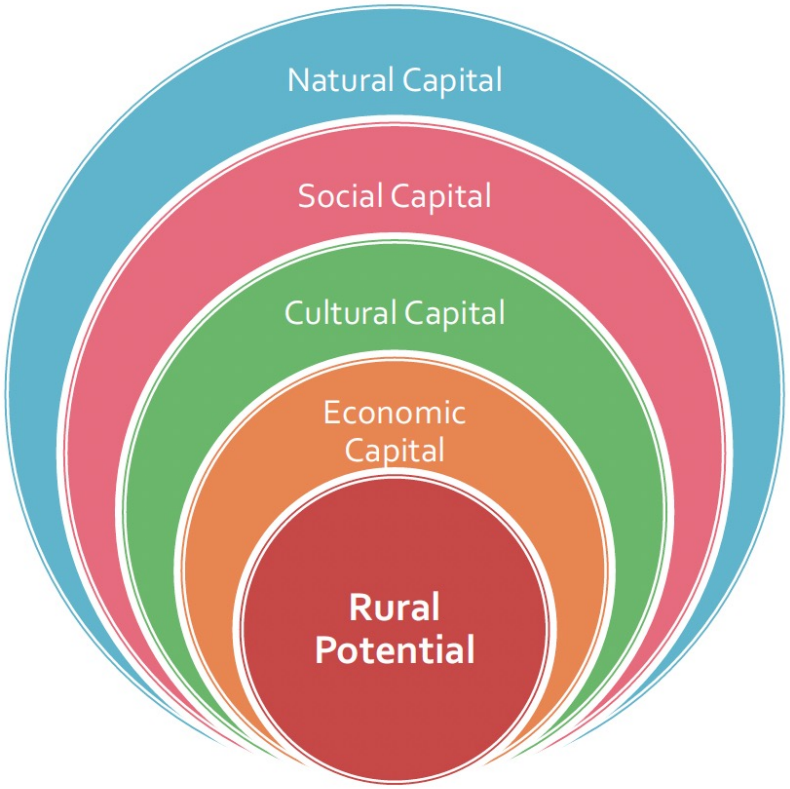
4 A 'capitals' framework for rurality

Groups of resources	Main elements of which:
Economic capital >> tangible values	Transport and communications infrastructure, workspace, local economic linkages, past private investment by firms and households, range of businesses in existence
Human capital >> local population	Education, skills, health, attitudes, confidence, entrepreneurship and capacity for risk taking of the local population
Social capital >> sectorial networks	Networks and partnerships linking the public, private and voluntary sectors, the quality of local institutions and governance, trust and the shared norms that facilitate cooperation
Cultural capital >> societal values	Political consensus, civic engagement, local history, customs and heritage, 'place identity' and people's sense of place, valorisation of culture and culture as a collective resource
Environmental capital >> appraised natural assets	Natural and man-made assets that are valorised by local residents, investors and visitors; location, embracing peripherality, perceptions of peripherality and proximity to other places

Courtney & Moseley, 2008

4 A 'capitals' framework for rurality

- A 'capitals' framework to **assess the value and potential of land**
- Multifunctional components that captures **land as an asset** – focused on wellbeing outcomes
- **Interplay of different capitals** – mutually reinforcing relationships
- **One form of capital can be 'converted' to another** (e.g., natural capital underpins prosperity, social capital to enhance natural capital)
- Unsustainable practices lead to erosion or **depletion of capitals**



Gkartzios, Gallent & Scott, 2022

5 The global countryside

Michael Woods' ongoing work on the Global-Rural

- Studies on globalisation within a rural context, drawing on Doreen Massey's **relational understanding of space**
- Woods argues that globalisation has led to **differentiated new geographies of the global countryside**, with rural places serving very different purposes – from playgrounds to dumping grounds

5 The global countryside:
a meta-narrative for understanding rural transformation

- Primary and secondary sectors inserted into spatially extensive commodity networks.
- Sites of 'increasing corporate concentration and integration, with corporate networks organised on a transnational scale' (Woods, 2007: 492).
- Both a supplier and an employer of international migrant labour.
- Select high amenity sites attract flows of the globally mobile population.
- Host to expanding and expansive flows of foreign direct investment, including into local and regional property markets.
- Established local approaches to human/non-human relations and their management increasingly challenged by global discourses.
- Landscapes bear the material imprint of globalisation processes.
- Increasing social polarisation at the local scale due to the combined effect of 1-4.
- Prone to the effects of re-scaling and re-siting of political authority and governance.
- As a corollary of 8 and 9, increasingly a site of contestation.

Woods, 2007

5 The global countryside:
emerging functions of the rural

The rural as …	
A playground …	… as a place of consumption for new second home-owners, tourists, food consumers
A dumping ground …	… for controversial unwanted land-uses (e.g. waste incinerators, prisons)
A post carbon landscape …	… a site for the (often contested) deployment of renewable energy – wind farms, solar farms, biomass
A resource sink …	… a site for extracting resources, often with short term 'boomtown' effects and limited long term re-investment in rural futures
A cultural heritage repository …	… tied into perceptions of rural 'authenticity' and nostalgia, cultural landscapes and the commodification of place
A food basket …	… as agriculture remains as a dominant land-use and function of rural places
A provider of ecosystem services …	… whereby ecosystems provide functions and services essential to human wellbeing, from recreation to flood alleviation or carbon storage
A social space …	… at the scale of everyday life, where people live and interact, often characterised by strong place attachment

Gallent & Scott, 2017

5 The global countryside:

- The urban countryside
  >> planetary urbanisation; fuzzy boundaries; city-regions

- The neoliberal countryside
  >> deregulation of markets for agri-food commodities; privatisation of state-owned land, natural resources and service providers

- The post-carbon countryside
  >> rural: suppliers of renewable energy; recreational sites; ecosystem services
  >> 'back-to-the-land' movement; ecovillage with self-sufficient sustainable lifestyles

>> not the same approach to be used in different parts of the world

DISCUSSION:

Based on what was previously elaborated during the lecture, reflect (individually or in small groups) on the following questions and provide clear argumentation for each answer. The answers may also be placed in Brightspace's Discussion section.

1. **What is the core idea / key concept associated with each of the five mentioned approaches to rurality? Can you trace the concepts such as 'social relationships', 'relational understanding of space', 'map & measure', 'power struggle', 'cultural capital' to each of the mentioned approaches?**

2. **What is the contemporary approach to defining rurality, and is this approach considered globally relevant? If so, what factors contribute to its global relevance?**

Key takeaways

Diverse ruralities
Imagined ruralities
Contested ruralities
Hybrid ruralities

- Material processes overlapping social constructions
- Interplay of local and global
- Blurring of urban and rural

Is rural a 'causal factor' in spatial change?
Does rural matter?
Is there a specific rural dimension to planning and policymaking?
Implications for planning?